The elections for a new President were held in the July of 2012. There was a buzz in Lutyens' Delhi that the Congress might consider Dr Singh for the post. The speculation was only partly true. No, Dr Singh was not being identified for a move to Rashtrapati Bhavan, but yes, it was an option that he himself was privately not ruling out. In fact, multiple sources have since confirmed to me that Dr Singh was very keen on being President. After all, he was now approaching his eightieth birthday—he had been prime minister for eight years. Only Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi had enjoyed such an extended tenure. He had achieved everything possible in public life—Rashtrapati Bhavan would be a nice sinecure.

This is where the Congress made another big mistake. Moving Dr Singh to Rashtrapati Bhavan and having a new prime minister would have been just the tonic a party in crisis needed. But Sonia Gandhi is notoriously risk-averse. Her aides claim she was faced with the TINA (there is no alternative) factor. Rahul Gandhi had shown no keenness, A.K. Antony was seen as too weak and P. Chidambaram as unsuited to coalition politics. Yes, there was Pranabda, a veteran Congressman, and an able crisis manager with a wide network of friends across parties. But the fact is, Sonia Gandhi never trusted Mukherjee as someone who would protect the family legacy.

It was an old story dating back to the mid-1980s when Mukherjee fell out with Rajiv Gandhi over reports that he had tried to usurp the prime ministership after Indira Gandhi's assassination. Once over lunch, Mukherjee told us how he had been a victim of circumstances. 'It was all a big misunderstanding of what actually happened. I had chosen to chair a Cabinet meeting after the assassination as the seniormost minister. I wasn't aiming to be the prime minister myself, but people around Rajiv convinced him that I was plotting to get the top job,' he said ruefully.

Sonia, though, has a long memory, neatly dividing the world into those with the Gandhis and those against the family. Somehow, Mukherjee, who could well have proven to be an able prime minister, never quite made the cut. Though he would never accept it publicly, the fact is Mukherjee had also never fully reconciled to Dr Singh as his leader. 'He wanted to be prime minister but knew Sonia would never make him one,' a Union